

Podcast Outline

An episode-length conversational version of the argument.

Working draft, subject to revision.

Target length about 45 minutes. One host, one guest. The goal is for a listener who has never heard the word “interpellation” to leave able to spot the move in the wild.

Cold open (2 min)

- Hook: “In October, Albertans vote on leaving Canada. Except the question on the ballot doesn’t actually ask that. Today, why the wording matters, and what a 1987 essay about Québec predicted about it.”
- Quotable: “A movement doesn’t talk to a people. It talks a people into existing.”

Segment 1 — The machine (8 min)

- Define the idea in plain terms: identification (you’re made to feel you share substance), interpellation (you’re “hailed,” and you turn around before you decide to), and “the people” as something made, not found.
- Talking point: every constituted people gets handed three things, a long backstory, a sense of acting as one, and a destination presented as their own.
- Quotable: “By the time you’ve agreed who you are, you’ve half-agreed what you want.”

Segment 2 — Québec, where it works (7 min)

- The canonical case: a thick national identity, a forward goal of sovereignty, a 1995 vote lost by a single point.
- Talking point: when the identity is deep, the destination feels like it just follows. That fusion is the thing to remember, because the next case breaks it.

Segment 3 — Alberta, where it strains (10 min)

- Young province, no ancient nation, so the “people” is built from grievance. That can hold an identity but struggles to point anywhere fixed.
- The evidence is in the movement’s own words: a law called “Sovereignty within a United Canada,” a ballot that only asks to start a process, polling where the grievance stays high but support to actually leave sits around a third.
- Quotable: “Albertans kept the ‘we.’ They’re just not sold on the exit.”

The turn — where the theory breaks (10 min)

- Two breakpoints. First, the detachable destination: thin substrate, loose telos. Second, the prior people.
- Treaties 6, 7, and 8 came before Alberta existed. In May 2026 a court quashed the petition because the government skipped its duty to consult First Nations. Québec saw the same thing in 1995, when the Cree voted 96 percent to stay.
- Talking point: this is the limit. You can summon a new people with words. You can't un-summon an older one that has treaties and a courtroom.
- Quotable: "Rhetoric can build a people. It can't clear the land first."

Segment 4 — Same machine, reversed (5 min)

- The US "true America" turn: identical move, opposite direction. Not a country to found, a country to restore, a people told it already exists and was robbed.
- Talking point: even the "3.5 percent" number does the work, handing a crowd proof of its own size.

Close (2 min)

- Bring it back to the listener: next time a movement tells you who you really are, notice the sentence right after it.
- Quotable: "The machine is good at making peoples. It's bad at taking them anywhere, and worse at the ground they're standing on."